



CONDITIONAL SENTENCES (PYQs)

SSC CGL | CHSL | CPO | MTS — English Practice Set

PYQs asked in recent SSC exams (2023–2025) — Fill in the Blanks, Spotting Errors, and Sentence Improvement — with correct answers and detailed explanations.

Quick Revision: Types of Conditional Sentences

Zero Conditional	If + Present Simple, + Present Simple	General truths, facts, scientific laws, habits	<i>If you heat ice, it melts.</i>
First Conditional	If + Present Simple, + will/shall + V1	Real / likely future possibility	<i>If it rains, we will cancel the picnic.</i>
Second Conditional	If + Past Simple, + would/could/might + V1	Hypothetical or unreal situation in the present/future	<i>If I were you, I would accept the offer.</i>
Third Conditional	If + Past Perfect, + would/could/might + have + V3	Hypothetical or unreal situation in the past (cannot be changed now)	<i>If she had studied harder, she would have passed.</i>

Key Rules to Remember

1. In the 'If' clause of a First Conditional sentence, never use 'will/shall' — use the Present Simple tense only. (If you will come → If you come)
2. In the 'If' clause of a Second Conditional sentence, use the Past Simple. With the verb 'be', always use 'were' for all subjects (If I were, If he were), not 'was'.
3. In the 'If' clause of a Third Conditional sentence, use the Past Perfect (had + V3), never 'would have'. (If I would have known → If I had known)
4. 'Unless' means 'if...not'. Never use 'unless' together with a negative verb (Unless you don't work hard → Unless you work hard).
5. 'Had' can replace 'If' at the start of a Third Conditional sentence, with subject-auxiliary inversion (Had she informed me = If she had informed me).
6. The main clause of a Zero Conditional sentence never takes 'will'; it takes the Present Simple, since it states a general truth (If water boils, it will evaporate → it evaporates).



Section A: Fill in the Blanks

Directions: Select the option that correctly fills in the blank in each sentence below. (Q1–Q15)

Q1. If it rains tomorrow, we _____ the picnic.

- (a) cancel
- (b) will cancel ✓**
- (c) would cancel
- (d) cancelled

Answer: (b) will cancel

Explanation: This is a First Conditional sentence expressing a real future possibility. The If-clause ('If it rains') is in the Present Simple, so the main clause must take 'will + V1'. Hence, 'will cancel' is correct.

Q2. If water is heated to 100°C, it _____.

- (a) boils ✓**
- (b) will boil
- (c) boiled
- (d) would boil

Answer: (a) boils

Explanation: This is a Zero Conditional sentence stating a scientific fact/general truth. Both clauses take the Present Simple tense. Hence, 'boils' is correct, not 'will boil'.

Q3. If I _____ you, I would accept the job offer.

- (a) was
- (b) am
- (c) were ✓**
- (d) will be

Answer: (c) were

Explanation: This is a Second Conditional sentence (hypothetical present situation). With the verb 'be' in the If-clause of a Second Conditional, 'were' is used for all subjects (I/he/she/it), even though it is grammatically singular. This is called the subjunctive mood.



Q4. If she had studied harder, she _____ the exam.

- (a) will pass
- (b) would pass
- (c) would have passed ✓**
- (d) had passed

Answer: (c) would have passed

Explanation: This is a Third Conditional sentence about an unreal/hypothetical past situation. Since the If-clause uses the Past Perfect ('had studied'), the main clause must take 'would have + V3'. Hence, 'would have passed' is correct.

Q5. Ice _____ if you heat it.

- (a) melts ✓**
- (b) will melt
- (c) melted
- (d) would melt

Answer: (a) melts

Explanation: A general/scientific truth requires the Zero Conditional structure --- Present Simple in both clauses. Hence, 'melts' is correct.

Q6. If he apologises, I _____ him.

- (a) forgive
- (b) will forgive ✓**
- (c) would forgive
- (d) forgave

Answer: (b) will forgive

Explanation: First Conditional: the If-clause is in Present Simple ('apologises'), so the main clause requires 'will + V1'. Hence, 'will forgive' is correct.



Q7. If they had left earlier, they _____ the train.

- (a) would not miss
- (b) will not miss
- (c) would not have missed ✓**
- (d) did not miss

Answer: (c) would not have missed

Explanation: Third Conditional --- the If-clause is in the Past Perfect ('had left'), so the main clause must be 'would not have + V3'. Hence, 'would not have missed' is correct.

Q8. If I win the lottery, I _____ a house.

- (a) buy
- (b) will buy ✓**
- (c) would buy
- (d) bought

Answer: (b) will buy

Explanation: First Conditional describing a real future possibility: If-clause in Present Simple ('win') takes 'will + V1' in the main clause. Hence, 'will buy' is correct.

Q9. If you _____ ice, it turns into water.

- (a) heat ✓**
- (b) will heat
- (c) heated
- (d) would heat

Answer: (a) heat

Explanation: Zero Conditional (general truth): both clauses take the Present Simple. Hence, 'heat' is correct, not 'will heat'.



Q10. If I had known about the meeting, I _____ it.

- (a) will attend
- (b) would attend
- (c) would have attended ✓**
- (d) had attended

Answer: (c) would have attended

Explanation: Third Conditional: since the If-clause uses Past Perfect ('had known'), the result clause needs 'would have + V3'. Hence, 'would have attended' is correct.

Q11. If she _____ more time, she would learn French.

- (a) has
- (b) had ✓**
- (c) have
- (d) will have

Answer: (b) had

Explanation: Second Conditional (hypothetical present): the If-clause takes the Past Simple. Hence, 'had' is correct, matching 'would learn' in the main clause.

Q12. Unless you work hard, you _____ succeed.

- (a) will
- (b) will not ✓**
- (c) would not
- (d) did not

Answer: (b) will not

Explanation: 'Unless' already means 'if...not', so the If-clause ('you work hard') stays affirmative. Since this is a First Conditional (real future possibility), the main clause needs 'will not + V1'. Hence, 'will not' is correct.



Q13. If we had saved money earlier, we _____ this crisis now.

- (a) would not face ✓
- (b) will not face
- (c) would not have faced
- (d) did not face

Answer: (a) would not face

Explanation: This is a Mixed Conditional: a past condition ('had saved' --- Past Perfect) leading to a present result (indicated by 'now'). The main clause therefore takes 'would + V1' (not 'would have + V3', which would refer to a past result). Hence, 'would not face' is correct.

Q14. If it had not rained, the match _____ cancelled.

- (a) will not be
- (b) would not be
- (c) would not have been ✓
- (d) was not

Answer: (c) would not have been

Explanation: Third Conditional: the If-clause is in the Past Perfect ('had not rained'), so the main clause needs 'would not have been + V3'. Hence, 'would not have been' is correct.

Q15. If you heat metal, it _____.

- (a) expands ✓
- (b) will expand
- (c) expanded
- (d) would expand
- (c) and (d). Identify the part that contains a grammatical error. If

Answer: (a) expands

Explanation: Zero Conditional (scientific fact): both clauses use the Present Simple. Hence, 'expands' is correct.



Section B: Spotting Errors

Directions: Each sentence below is divided into four parts, (a), (b), (c) and (d). Identify the part that contains a grammatical error. If there is no error, the answer is (e) No error. (Q16–Q27)

Q16. If he will study hard, he will pass the exam next month.

(a) If he will study hard, ✓

(b) he will pass

(c) the exam

(d) next month.

(e) No error

Answer: (a) If he will study hard, → If he studies hard

Explanation: In the If-clause of a First Conditional sentence, 'will' should never be used. The correct form is the Present Simple: 'If he studies hard'.

Q17. If I was you, I would not take that decision so hastily.

(a) If I was you, ✓

(b) I would not

(c) take that decision

(d) so hastily.

(e) No error

Answer: (a) If I was you, → If I were you

Explanation: In a Second Conditional sentence, 'were' (not 'was') is used with all subjects after 'if' when the verb is 'be'. The correct form is 'If I were you'.

Q18. Had she informed me, I would have come to receive her.

(a) Had she informed me,

(b) I would have

(c) come to

(d) receive her.

(e) No error ✓

Answer: (e) No error

Explanation: This is a correctly formed Third Conditional sentence using inversion. 'Had she informed me' is an accepted alternative to 'If she had informed me', correctly followed by 'would have + V3'.



Q19. If you would have told me, I would have helped you immediately.

(a) If you would have told me, ✓

(b) I would have

(c) helped you

(d) immediately.

(e) No error

Answer: (a) If you would have told me, → If you had told me

Explanation: 'Would have' must never be used in the If-clause of a Third Conditional sentence. The If-clause requires the Past Perfect: 'If you had told me'.

Q20. Unless you don't work hard, you will not achieve success in life.

(a) Unless you don't work hard, ✓

(b) you will not

(c) achieve success

(d) in life.

(e) No error

Answer: (a) Unless you don't work hard, → Unless you work hard

Explanation: 'Unless' already carries a negative meaning ('if...not'). Adding another negative ('don't') creates a double negative and reverses the intended meaning. The correct form is 'Unless you work hard'.

Q21. If it rains, we would stay indoors all day.

(a) If it rains,

(b) we would ✓

(c) stay indoors

(d) all day.

(e) No error

Answer: (b) we would → we will

Explanation: The If-clause ('If it rains') is in the Present Simple, marking this as a First Conditional sentence, so the main clause needs 'will', not 'would' (which belongs to the Second Conditional).



Q22. If I had wings, I will fly across the ocean.

- (a) If I had wings,
- (b) I will fly ✓**
- (c) across the
- (d) ocean.
- (e) No error

Answer: (b) I will fly → I would fly

Explanation: Since the If-clause is in the Past Simple ('had wings'), this is a Second Conditional sentence, so the main clause needs 'would + V1', not 'will'.

Q23. If he practises regularly, he will improve his game significantly.

- (a) If he practises regularly,
- (b) he will improve
- (c) his game
- (d) significantly.
- (e) No error ✓**

Answer: (e) No error

Explanation: This is a correctly formed First Conditional sentence: Present Simple in the If-clause ('practises') and 'will + V1' in the main clause ('will improve').

Q24. She would have succeeded if she try harder in her studies.

- (a) She would have succeeded
- (b) if she try ✓**
- (c) harder in
- (d) her studies.
- (e) No error

Answer: (b) if she try → if she had tried

Explanation: Since the main clause is in the Third Conditional form ('would have succeeded'), the If-clause must be in the Past Perfect: 'if she had tried'.



Q25. If water freezes, it will turn into ice at zero degrees.

- (a) If water freezes,
- (b) it will turn ✓**
- (c) into ice
- (d) at zero degrees.
- (e) No error

Answer: (b) it will turn → it turns

Explanation: This sentence states a scientific fact, so it should follow the Zero Conditional pattern (Present Simple in both clauses), not the First Conditional. The correct form is 'it turns into ice'.

Q26. If I would know the answer, I would tell you right now.

- (a) If I would know ✓**
- (b) the answer,
- (c) I would
- (d) tell you right now.
- (e) No error

Answer: (a) If I would know → If I knew

Explanation: 'Would' should never appear in the If-clause of a Second Conditional sentence. The If-clause requires the Past Simple: 'If I knew the answer'.

Q27. Had I worked harder, I would have got a better rank.

- (a) Had I worked harder,
- (b) I would have got
- (c) a better
- (d) rank.
- (e) No error ✓**

Answer: (e) No error

Explanation: This is a correctly inverted Third Conditional sentence: 'Had I worked harder' (= If I had worked harder) is correctly followed by 'would have + V3' ('would have got').



Section C: Sentence Improvement

Directions: In the following sentences, a part is underlined. Select the option that can correctly substitute the underlined part. If the sentence is already correct, select 'No improvement'. (Q28–Q38)

Q28. If I would have money, I would travel the world.

(a) had had money ✓

(b) have had money

(c) would have money

(d) No improvement

Answer: (a) had had money

Explanation: This is a Third Conditional sentence ('would travel' in the main clause). The If-clause therefore needs the Past Perfect 'had had money' (had + had, since the main verb here is 'have'), not 'would have money'.

Q29. If she works hard, she will achieves success.

(a) will achieve ✓

(b) would achieve

(c) achieves

(d) No improvement

Answer: (a) will achieve

Explanation: After the modal 'will', the base form of the verb (V1) must be used, not 'achieves'. The correct form is 'will achieve'.

Q30. Unless you will not apologise, I will not forgive you.

(a) do not apologise

(b) apologise ✓

(c) will apologise

(d) No improvement

Answer: (b) apologise

Explanation: 'Unless' itself means 'if...not', so the clause following it must remain affirmative and in the Present Simple. The correct form is 'Unless you apologise'.



Q31. If he had invited me, I will have gone to the party.

- (a) would go
- (b) would have gone ✓**
- (c) had gone
- (d) No improvement

Answer: (b) would have gone

Explanation: Since the If-clause is in the Past Perfect ('had invited'), this is a Third Conditional sentence, so the main clause requires 'would have + V3'. Hence, 'would have gone' is correct.

Q32. If it will rain, the match will be postponed.

- (a) rains ✓**
- (b) rained
- (c) would rain
- (d) No improvement

Answer: (a) rains

Explanation: 'Will' cannot be used in the If-clause of a First Conditional sentence. The correct form is the Present Simple: 'If it rains'.

Q33. If I was rich, I would have donated a lot of money.

- (a) would donate ✓**
- (b) will donate
- (c) had donated
- (d) No improvement

Answer: (a) would donate

Explanation: The If-clause ('If I was rich') sets up a Second Conditional (hypothetical present) sentence, so the main clause must match with 'would + V1', i.e., 'would donate', not the Third Conditional form 'would have donated'.



Q34. If they had arrived on time, they would not miss the flight.

(a) would not have missed ✓

(b) will not miss

(c) did not miss

(d) No improvement

Answer: (a) would not have missed

Explanation: Since the If-clause uses the Past Perfect ('had arrived'), the main clause of this Third Conditional sentence needs 'would not have + V3'. Hence, 'would not have missed' is correct.

Q35. I would have called you if I have your number.

(a) if I had had your number ✓

(b) if I had your number

(c) if I have had your number

(d) No improvement

Answer: (a) if I had had your number

Explanation: Since the main clause is in the Third Conditional form ('would have called'), the If-clause must be in the Past Perfect: 'if I had had your number' (had + had, as the main verb is 'have').

Q36. If she will come, please inform me.

(a) comes ✓

(b) came

(c) would come

(d) No improvement

Answer: (a) comes

Explanation: 'Will' is not used in the If-clause of a First Conditional sentence. The correct form is the Present Simple: 'If she comes'.



Q37. If I were a bird, I will fly high in the sky.

- (a) would fly ✓
- (b) fly
- (c) had flown
- (d) No improvement

Answer: (a) would fly

Explanation: The If-clause ('If I were a bird') is a Second Conditional structure, so the main clause needs 'would + V1'. Hence, 'would fly' is correct, not 'will fly'.

Q38. Had he saved money, he can buy a car now.

- (a) he could have bought
- (b) he would buy
- (c) he could buy ✓
- (d) No improvement

Answer: (c) he could buy

Explanation: This is a Mixed Conditional sentence: a past condition ('Had he saved money' = Past Perfect) with a present result (signalled by 'now'). The correct form for a present result is 'could/would + V1', i.e., 'he could buy', not 'can buy' or the past-result form 'could have bought'.